

ETHNIC & LINGUISTIC ELEMENTS IN INDIAN POPULATION

Anthropology Optional Paper 1 (Units 1.9, 1.10) | Sarrthi IAS Foundation L-21 | Nataraj Sir

CHAPTER OVERVIEW MAP

PART I: Racial Classification

Risley (7 types) → Guha (6 types, most accepted) → Sarkar (6 elements, cephalic index)

PART II: Linguistic Classification

4 language families: Austric (1.3%) | Dravidian (20%) | Sino-Tibetan (0.85%) | Indo-European (73%)

PART III: Relevance & Challenges

Bridge languages | Unity in diversity | Linguistic conflicts & movements | Identity politics

PART I: RACIAL / ETHNIC CLASSIFICATION

Many scholars attempted racial classification of India. Three classifications stand out: **Risley, Guha, and S.S. Sarkar.**

1. RISLEY'S CLASSIFICATION (1915)

Sir Herbert Hope Risley — British civil servant (19th century). First to attempt **scientific classification** of India's racial groups. Used **anthropometric techniques**, especially the **nasal index** (ratio of nose breadth to height). Linked physical traits with **caste & community**. **Census Commissioner for 1901**. Published **"The Peoples of India" (1915)**. Classified Indians into **7 racial categories**.

Risley's 7 Racial Types

Type	Location	Representatives	Key Features
1. Turko-Iranian	Baluchistan, Afghanistan, NW India	Pathans	Tall, well built, fair, long head, narrow/moderate nose, thick facial hair
2. Indo-Aryan	J&K, Punjab, Haryana, Rajasthan (migrated from Central Asia)	Rajputs, Khatri, Jats	Tall, fair, long arms, long head, narrow & prominent nose, broad shoulders, slim to heavy body
3. Scytho-Dravidian	Sind (Pakistan), Gujarat, Maharashtra, Karnataka, Rajasthan, UP (mixture of Scythians & Dravidians)	Marathas	Short, long head, moderate nose, light brown to fair, scanty body hair
4. Aryo-Dravidian	Rajasthan, UP, Bihar (mixture of Aryans & Dravidians)	Brahmins & SCs both	Short, long head, complexion light brown to black, medium to broad nose
5. Mongolo-Dravidian	West Bengal, Orissa (Brahmins & Kayasthas)	—	Broad head, dark complexion, flat nose, short to medium height, thick facial hair
6. Mongoloid	Himalayan & sub-Himalayan (Ladakh to NE India, Tarai belt)	Kinnets, Lepchas, Bhutias, Tharus	Short, yellowish, medium broad nose, flat face, oblique eyes with epicanthic fold
7. Dravidian	South India (AP, KA, KL, TN), Chhattisgarh, Jharkhand, S. MP, Orissa, S. Rajasthan	Santhals, Todas, Juangs, Gonds, Bhils	Short, dark, hairy body, curly hair, long head, broad nose

Criticisms of Risley

- Small Sample Size:** Only 42 castes & tribes out of 87 — **Malhotra & Vasulu (2019)**
- Methodology:** Concerns about selection process and clarity
- Intra-Population Diversity:** Anthropometric measurements show greater intra-population than inter-group diversity (due to non-random mating)
- Neglect of Environmental Factors:** **Malhotra & Vasulu (2019)** — did not adequately consider environmental factors

Modern View: Risley's classification is historically important, but modern anthropology no longer accepts rigid racial types. Today focus is on **genetics, populations, and continuous variation** rather than fixed racial boxes.

2. GUHA'S CLASSIFICATION (Most Widely Accepted)

B.S. Guha — Classification based on **scientific evidence**. Used **anthropometric surveys** conducted preceding the **1931 Census**. Founded on a **firm scientific foundation** — considered the **most widely accepted and acceptable racial classification to date**. Commonly used in any study of the Indian population.

GUHA'S 6 BROAD RACIAL TYPES					
1. Negrito Oldest layer. Andamanese (Onge, Jarawa), Irula, Kadars		2. Proto-Australoid Most tribes of Central & South India. Oraons, Santhals, Mundas		3. Mongoloid Palaeo-Mongoloid (Long & Broad headed) + Tibeto-Mongoloid	
4. Mediterranean Paleo-Med + Mediterranean + Oriental (3 sub-types)		5. Western Brachycephals Alpinoid + Dinaric + Armenoid (3 sub-types)		6. Nordic Tall, fair, blue/grey eyes. Kho/Chitrali people	

Detailed Breakdown of Guha's Types

Type / Sub-type	Key Features	Examples	Special Notes
1. NEGRITO	Dark skin, short stature, frizzy hair (long/short spirals), small/medium/long/broad head with bulbous forehead, flat & broad nose, everted & thick lips	Irula, Kadars, Andamanese (Onge, Jarawa)	Earliest inhabitants
2. PROTO-AUSTRALOID	Short height, dark brown to nearly black skin, wavy/curly hair, prominent supraorbital ridges	Oraons, Santhals, Mundas of Chota Nagpur	Found among almost all tribes of Central & Southern India
3. MONGOLOID — Scanty hair on face & body, oblique eyes with epicanthic fold, flat face, prominent cheekbones, straight hair. Divided into 2 sub-groups:			
a) Palaeo-Mongoloid (Long-headed)	Long head, medium stature, medium nose, prominent cheekbones, dark to light brown skin, short flat face	Sema Nagas of Assam	Sub-Himalayan region; Assam & Burma Frontier
a) Palaeo-Mongoloid (Broad-headed)	Broad head, round face, dark skin, medium nose, more prominent epicanthic fold	Hill tribes of Chittagong — Chakmas	—
b) Tibeto-Mongoloid	Broad & massive head, tall, long flat face, medium to long nose, oblique eyes, almost no body hair, light brown skin	Tibetans of Bhutan & Sikkim	—
4. MEDITERRANEAN — Divided into 3 distinct racial types:			
a) Paleo-Mediterranean	Long head, bulbous forehead, high vault, medium stature, small & broad nose, narrow face, pointed chin, scanty hair, dark skin	Tamil Brahmins of Madurai, Telugu Brahmins	Probably introduced megalithic culture to India. Dravidian speakers of South India
b) Mediterranean	Long head, arched forehead, narrow nose, medium to tall, light skin, well-developed chin, dark hair, plentiful body hair	Nambudiri Brahmins of Cochin	Probably responsible for building Indus Valley Civilization
c) Oriental Type	Resembles Mediterranean except nose is long and convex	Punjabi Chattris, Pathans	—
5. WESTERN BRACHYCEPHALS — Divided into 3 types:			
a) Alpinoid	Broad head, medium stature, prominent nose, rounded face, abundant hair, light skin	Bania of Gujarat, Kathi of Kathiawar	—
b) Dinaric	Broad head, very long & convex nose, long face, very tall, dark skin/eyes/hair	Brahmins of Bengal	—
c) Armenoid	Resembles Dinarics but occiput much more developed, nose very prominent	Parsis of Bombay	—
6. NORDIC	Long head, arched forehead, straight & high-bridged nose, tall with strong jaw & robust body, blue/grey eyes, fair (reddish) skin	Kho or Chitrali people of Gilgit-Baltistan (Pakistan)	—

Guha's Key Conclusion: Brachycephals (broad-headed people) dominate the Indian population. Prior to Guha, this was not widely held. Scholars have overwhelmingly endorsed Guha's categorisation — no other investigation or survey on scientific lines of this extent has been done.

Criticisms of Guha

1. **Negrito & Foreign Origin:** Identification of Negrito elements and attribution of foreign origins criticized by **Kalla (1994)**
2. **Sample Size:** Smaller sample sizes; questions about representativeness
3. **Selection of Tribal Groups:** Questions about selection criteria — **Malhotra & Vasulu (2019)**
4. **Proto-Nordics & Indo-Aryan Invasion:** Did not consider other types like Alpino-Dinarics
5. **Brachycephalic Mongoloid Elements:** **Sarkar criticized** this — argued brachycephalic form was restricted, not a major racial type

Modern View: Today we prefer to study **genetic variation and clines** instead of rigid racial boxes. Guha's work remains an early but structured approach.

3. S.S. SARKAR'S CLASSIFICATION (1954)

S.S. Sarkar (1954) — Classified Indian population mainly on the basis of **cephalic index (head shape)**. Concluded India was predominantly **dolichocephalic (long-headed)**, but also had **mesocephalic (medium-headed)** and **brachycephalic (broad-headed)** groups. Identified **6 ethnic elements**.

Sarkar's 6 Ethnic Elements

#	Type	Location	Key Features	Special Notes
1	Australoid	South India — Urali, Paniyan, Kadar	Short stature, dark complexion, dolichocephalic head, broad (platyrrhine) nose, wavy hair	Also called proto-Australoid, pre-Dravidian, Veddid. Oldest substratum of Indian population. Concentrated among lower castes
2	Indo-Aryan	Baltics of Hindukush mountains (Central Asia migrants)	Tall stature, fair skin & eyes, lighter hair, long & massive head, high cranial capacity, robust body	—
3	Irano-Scythian	E. Bihar, Bengal, Assam, Gujarat, Maharashtra, Mysore, Deccan	Medium stature, mesocephalic head (index 77-79)	Entered India from NW. Visible in many populations due to southward migration along Indus valley
4	Mundari-speaking	Chota Nagpur, Orissa hills, MP (river valleys & plateaus of eastern central India)	Stocky, short stature, long head, lighter skin than Australoids, thick straight hair (similar to Mongoloids)	Migrated from the east. Show affinities with Mongoloid type
5	Far Eastern (Malayan-Polynesian)	Coastal populations of eastern India (e.g., Chittagong hill tracts)	Darker skin, short stature, broad to wavy head, tendency to obesity	Linked to ancient contact with SE Asian islanders
6	Mongolian	NE borders, Himalayan foothills	Yellowish skin, scanty body & facial hair, Mongolian eye fold, flat face	—

Criticisms of Sarkar

1. **Overemphasis on Cephalic Index:** Single trait not sufficient to capture racial diversity
2. **Rejection of Negrito Element:** Denied Negrito presence in India based on his Kadar study (1959). Many anthropologists disagree
3. **Limited Scope of Data:** Surveys not as extensive as Guha's (1931 Census surveys)
4. **Simplification of Complex Mixtures:** Indian population highly mixed; 6-type model oversimplifies
5. **Contradiction with Guha:** Opposed Guha's finding that brachycephals dominate India; insisted dolichocephaly was predominant — led to scholarly debate

COMPARISON: Three Racial Classifications

Feature	Risley (1915)	Guha (1931 Census)	S.S. Sarkar (1954)
No. of Types	7	6 (with sub-types = ~14)	6
Main Criterion	Nasal index (anthropometric)	Comprehensive anthropometric surveys	Cephalic index (head shape)
Key Finding	Caste linked to race	Brachycephals dominate India	India predominantly dolichocephalic
Acceptance	Historically important, now outdated	Most widely accepted	Criticised for limited scope
Negrito?	Not separately identified	Yes — Andamanese, Irula, Kadars	Denied (based on Kadar study 1959)
Key Critics	Malhotra & Vasulu (2019)	Kalla (1994); Malhotra & Vasulu (2019); Sarkar	Multiple scholars

PART II: LINGUISTIC CLASSIFICATION OF INDIA

India is a land of great linguistic diversity. This has attracted scholars and linguists for centuries.

Why India has Linguistic Diversity — 2 Main Reasons

- 1. India has many different racial groups, each bringing their own speech patterns
- 2. India has prolonged geographical isolation in some areas — mountains, deserts, forests kept groups apart, allowing separate languages to evolve

Language gives regional identity, sense of belonging, and creates social & emotional integration among speakers of the same tongue.

4 Language Families of India

S.No	Family (Local Name)	% Pop.	Region	Examples
1	Austrie (Nishad)	1.3%	Central India	Santali, Mundari, etc.
2	Dravidian (Dravid)	20%	South India	Telugu, Tamil, Kannada, etc.
3	Sino-Tibetan (Kirat)	0.85%	North-Eastern India	Assamese, Khasi, Manipuri, etc.
4	Indo-European (Aryan)	73%	Punjab & Sindhi region	Marathi, Konkani, Rajasthani, etc.

LINGUISTIC FAMILIES AT A GLANCE

Indo-European (73%)

Largest family. North & Central India. Hindi, Bengali, Marathi, Gujarati, Punjabi, Urdu

Dravidian (20%)

South India. Tamil, Telugu, Kannada, Malayalam. Tamil = one of world's oldest living languages

Austrie (1.3%)

Central Indian tribes. Munda group: Santali, Mundari. Some of India's most ancient languages

Sino-Tibetan (0.85%)

NE India & Himalayan foothills. Assamese, Khasi, Manipuri, Bodo, Naga languages

Relevance of Linguistic Diversity for India Today

Linguistic diversity reflects India's plural identity and the principle of unity in diversity. It allows every region to preserve its heritage while contributing to a shared national culture.

Bridge Languages & Their Contributions

Language	Period	Contribution
Sanskrit	Ancient	Bridge between Indo-European & Dravidian tongues. Produced Ramayana, Mahabharata, Upanishads, Panini's Ashtadhyayi. Pan-Indian influence
Tamil	Ancient	One of the oldest living languages (2000+ years). Sangam literature, Thirukkural. Spoken in Sri Lanka, Singapore, Malaysia
Persian	Medieval	Deeply influenced Marathi, Kannada, Telugu, Tamil, Bengali. Enriched court traditions and literature
Hindi-Urdu	Medieval & Modern	Language of the masses (North India). Gandhi proposed Hindustani as link language
English	Modern	India's global link. Enabled Indians to excel in science, tech, business internationally

🖋️ Wilhelm von Humboldt, the noted linguist, reminds us: "Every language is a worldview." India's many languages form countless ways of seeing the world — making our civilisation rich. 🖋️ [Handwritten — blank filled in class]

Challenges of Linguistic Diversity in India

Paul Brass reminds us that in multi-ethnic societies, language often becomes a mobilising symbol of identity. India's history reflects this tension.

Key Linguistic Conflicts & Movements

Movement	State	Details	Key Scholar/Person
Anti-Hindi Agitations (1960s)	Tamil Nadu	Opposition to Hindi imposition brought DMK to power, ending Congress dominance	Robert Hardgrave — reshaped Tamil politics permanently
Gokak Agitation (1980s)	Karnataka	Demanded Kannada as first language in schools. Milestone in Kannada pride	Poet Kuvempu , actor Dr. Rajkumar
Marathi Mandatory	Maharashtra	Made Marathi mandatory in CBSE & ICSE schools up to Class 10	To protect Marathi identity
Assamese Linguistic Pride	Assam	Assamese pride clashed with minority language rights	Sanjib Baruah — shaped Assamese subnationalism
Bhojpuri Movement	National	Bhojpuri spoken in 27 countries, demands 8th Schedule status	Yogi Adityanath argued for recognition
Meitei (Manipuri)	Manipur	Won 8th Schedule recognition (1992) . Demands for classical status continue	—
Fear of Hindi Imposition	Tamil Nadu, West Bengal	States resist centralising language policies	Yogendra Singh — Indian modernity reshapes but does not erase traditions

 **Jawaharlal Nehru** argued, India is a "**composite culture**" shaped by many streams. Linguistic diversity is both an **asset** and a **challenge**. Every language is part of India's collective identity — languages remain a **living symbol of unity in diversity**.  **[Handwritten — blank filled in class]**

QUICK-REVISION CHEAT SHEET

Topic	Main Points (Keywords)	Key Scholars	Examples	Key Case Studies
Risley's Classification	7 types, nasal index, anthropometric, Census Commissioner 1901, "Peoples of India" 1915, caste linked to race	H.H. Risley; Critics: Malhotra & Vasulu (2019)	Pathans (Turko-Iranian), Rajputs/Jats (Indo-Aryan), Marathas (Scytho-Dravidian), Santhals/Todas/Gonds (Dravidian)	Only 42 out of 87 castes sampled; modern shift to genetics & continuous variation
Guha's Classification	6 types (~14 with sub-types), 1931 Census surveys, most accepted, anthropometric, brachycephals dominate India	B.S. Guha; Critics: Kalla (1994), Malhotra & Vasulu (2019), Sarkar	Andamanese/Irula (Negrito), Oraons/Santhals (Proto-Australoid), Sema Nagas/Chakmas (Mongoloid), Tamil Brahmins (Paleo-Med), Nambudiri Brahmins (Med), Parsis (Armenoid), Kho (Nordic)	Mediterranean type built Indus Valley Civilization; Paleo-Med introduced megalithic culture
Sarkar's Classification	6 elements, 1954, cephalic index, dolichocephalic predominant, denied Negrito, contradicted Guha	S.S. Sarkar; Kadar study (1959)	Urali/Paniyan/Kadar (Australoid), Mundari-speaking people (Chota Nagpur)	Sarkar vs Guha debate: dolichocephaly vs brachycephaly dominance
4 Language Families	Indo-European (73%), Dravidian (20%), Austric (1.3%), Sino-Tibetan (0.85%); racial groups + geographic isolation	 Wilhelm von Humboldt ("Every language is a worldview")	Santali/Mundari (Austric), Telugu/Tamil (Dravidian), Khasi/Manipuri (Sino-Tibetan), Marathi/Hindi (Indo-European)	Tamil — oldest living language (2000+ yrs); Sanskrit = bridge language; Persian influenced 5 Indian languages
Linguistic Challenges	Language as identity symbol, mobilisation tool, federal balance, 8th Schedule demands, anti-Hindi sentiment	Paul Brass, Robert Hardgrave, Sanjib Baruah, Yogendra Singh, Kuvempu,  Nehru	Anti-Hindi (TN 1960s), Gokak (Karnataka 1980s), Bhojpuri (8th Sched demand), Meitei (1992 recognition)	DMK's rise through anti-Hindi movement; Gokak agitation & Kannada pride; composite culture concept

 Handwritten Annotations Index

#	Location in Notes	Handwritten Content	Significance
1	Linguistic Relevance section — blank for linguist name	" Wilhelm von Humboldt " — "Every language is a worldview"	Famous quote for UPSC intros/conclusions on linguistic diversity
2	Conclusion section — blank for composite culture scholar	" Jawaharlal Nehru " — India is a "composite culture" shaped by many streams	Use in essays on diversity, national integration, linguistic unity

BUILDING BLOCKS — What Matters Most for UPSC

BLOCK 1: Racial Classification — Core Framework

Use when asked: "Discuss racial elements in Indian population" / "Ethnic diversity in India"

Must-mention scholars: Risley (7 types, nasal index) → Guha (6 types, most accepted, 1931 Census) → Sarkar (6 elements, cephalic index, 1954)

Must-mention concept: Modern shift from racial typology to **genetics, populations, continuous variation & clines**

Key critics: Malhotra & Vasulu (2019), Kalla (1994)

BLOCK 2: Guha's Classification — Deep Dive (Most Important)

Use when asked: "Critically examine Guha's racial classification" / "Most accepted classification"

Must-mention: 6 types (Negrito, Proto-Australoid, Mongoloid, Mediterranean, Western Brachycephals, Nordic) with **sub-types**

Key finding: Brachycephals dominate India (contradicted by Sarkar)

Cultural links: Mediterranean type → Indus Valley Civilization; Paleo-Mediterranean → megalithic culture

Examples to use: Andamanese/Onge/Jarawa (Negrito), Oraons/Santhals/Mundas (Proto-Australoid), Sema Nagas (Mongoloid), Nambudiri Brahmins (Mediterranean), Parsis of Bombay (Armenoid)

BLOCK 3: Risley vs Guha vs Sarkar — Comparison

Use when asked: "Compare racial classifications of Indian population"

Comparison axes: Year, basis (nasal vs anthropometric vs cephalic), number of types, key finding, acceptance level

Key debate: Guha says brachycephals dominate ≠ Sarkar says dolichocephaly predominant

Sarkar's unique point: Denied Negrito presence based on Kadar study (1959)

Closing line: All three are now seen as early stages; modern anthropology uses genetic variation and clines

BLOCK 4: Linguistic Diversity — Framework

Use when asked: "Linguistic elements in Indian population" / "Unity in diversity through language"

Must-mention: 4 families with % — Indo-European (73%), Dravidian (20%), Austric (1.3%), Sino-Tibetan (0.85%)

Bridge languages: Sanskrit (ancient bridge), Tamil (oldest living), Persian (medieval influence), Hindi-Urdu (masses), English (global link)

Opening quote: 🗣️ Wilhelm von Humboldt — "Every language is a worldview"

Why diversity exists: Multiple racial groups + prolonged geographical isolation

BLOCK 5: Linguistic Conflicts & Identity Politics

Use when asked: "Language and identity in India" / "Challenges of linguistic diversity"

Theory: Paul Brass — language as mobilising symbol of identity

Case studies (must-use):

- Anti-Hindi Agitations (TN, 1960s) — DMK rise, Robert Hardgrave
- Gokak Agitation (Karnataka, 1980s) — Kuvempu, Dr. Rajkumar
- 8th Schedule demands — Bhojpuri, Meitei (won 1992)

Yogendra Singh: Indian modernity reshapes traditions, does not erase them

Closing: 🗣️ Nehru — India is a "composite culture" — languages are a living symbol of unity in diversity

BLOCK 6: Universal Scholar Toolkit for This Chapter

Scholar	Key Contribution	Use In
H.H. Risley	First racial classification; 7 types; nasal index; "Peoples of India" 1915	Racial classification Qs
B.S. Guha	Most accepted classification; 6 types; 1931 Census; brachycephals dominate	Any racial diversity Q
S.S. Sarkar	1954; cephalic index; 6 elements; denied Negrito; dolichocephalic predominance	Comparison / criticism Qs
Malhotra & Vasulu (2019)	Critics of Risley & Guha — sample size, environmental factors, tribal selection	Criticism sections
Kalla (1994)	Criticized Guha's Negrito identification & foreign origin attribution	Guha criticism
Paul Brass	Language = mobilising symbol of identity in multi-ethnic societies	Linguistic conflict Qs
Robert Hardgrave	Anti-Hindi agitations reshaped Tamil politics permanently	TN language movement
Sanjib Baruah	Assamese subnationalism shaped by linguistic movements	Regionalism / NE India
Yogendra Singh	Indian modernity reshapes but does not erase traditions	Modernisation / language Qs
Kuvempu & Dr. Rajkumar	Supporters of Gokak Agitation (Kannada as first language)	Karnataka language identity
 Wilhelm von Humboldt	"Every language is a worldview"	Opening/closing lines on language
 Jawaharlal Nehru	India as a "composite culture" shaped by many streams	Unity in diversity essays

Source: Sarrthi IAS Anthropology Optional Foundation — Lecture 21, Nataraj Sir | UPSC CSE 2026



= Handwritten annotation from class notes | Prepared for exam-ready revision